INTERGENERATIONAL TRANSMISSION OF HOPELESSNESS WITHIN HMONG FAMILIES

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INTRODUCTION

- Hopelessness has been researched in recent years, especially in psychology as a subsection of depression (Beck et al, 2003; Fryer, 1998; Woolfork, 2002). Studies found that people who feel hopeless are also more likely to report less control over their own lives and that immigrants and low-income people are much more vulnerable to feel powerless (Bullough, 1972; Isrole, 1956).
- There are limited studies investigating the transmission of hopelessness between parents and children in immigrant populations, especially Hmong.
- The purpose of this study was to answer the following research questions:
  1. What is considered hopelessness?
  2. What contributes to hopelessness?
  3. What transmits to children and why?

METHODOLOGY

- Data used for this poster were from the Hmong Youth Delinquency Project (Xiong, 2005). Only open-ended interview transcripts were analyzed to answer the research questions.
- The sample included 15 parents (7 fathers and 8 mothers), ages ranged from 37 to 56 (mean= 43.47; SD=4.955) and 9 adolescents (2 boys and 7 girls), ages ranged from13 to 19 (mean=15.89; SD=1.691).
- All parents were born in Laos and had not fully acculturated to the American culture (mean acculturation score = 1.64 out of scale 1 – 4).
- 89% of adolescents were either born in the refugee camp or in the United States.
- Data analyses were based on the Grounded Theory procedures.

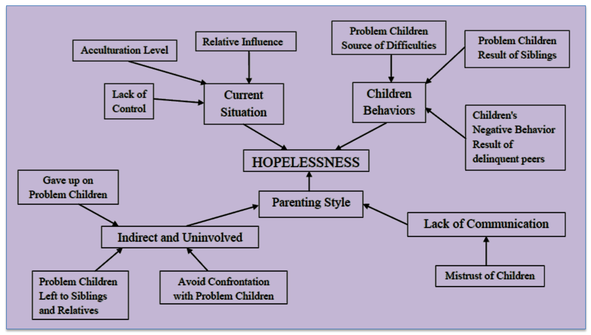
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Photo Credit: Acknowledgements to my Family for allowing me to use these photos.



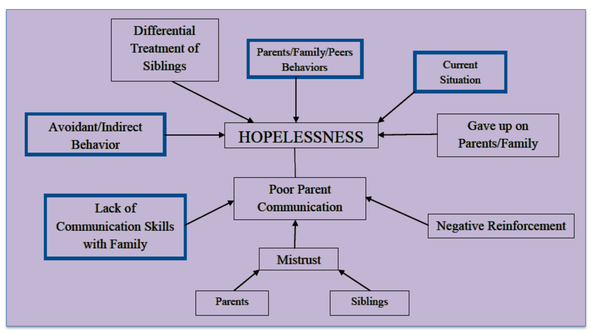
RESULTS

Table 1. What Contributes to Parents' Hopelessness?



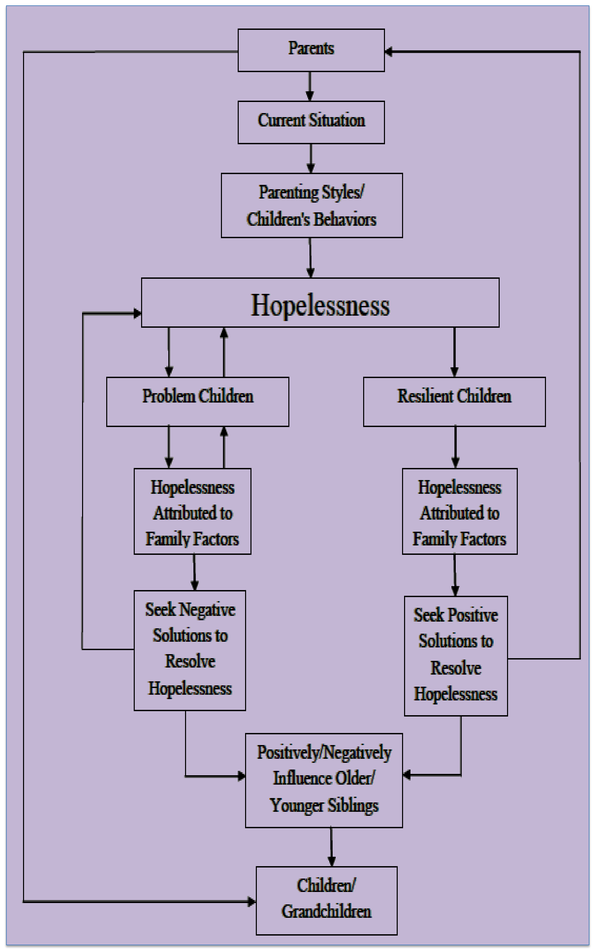
Note. We found that the most proximal contributions to parents' hopelessness included parents' current situation, children's problem behaviors, and parents' parenting styles.

Table 2. What Traits Transmit from Parents to Children?



Note. We found the following evidence of transmissions between parents' and children's data: Current Situation, Parent/Peer Behaviors, Avoidant/Indirect Behavior and Lack of Communication Skills with Family.

Table 3. What Explains the Intergenerational Transmission of Hopelessness?



Note. We found that parents' hopelessness is the result of the intersection between the current situation (i.e., the legal/judicial system, employment opportunities, neighborhood condition, etc.), the old parenting (hierarchical) style, and children's problem behavior. We also found that parents' hopelessness is more likely to transmit to children with certain behavioral problems.

DISCUSSION

- Overall, our study found that parents tend to base their hope on their children when they have very little control over their lives and environment. However, when children deviate from the norm, this deviation tends to create a cycle of hopelessness for both generations.
- This finding raises a real concern since it can affect the parents' and children's health and mental health.
- This study contributes to the literature by:
  1. Expanding the literature on hopelessness in general and intergenerational transmission of hopelessness in Hmong families in particular.
  2. Adding additional knowledge to help us understand the nature and transmission process of hopelessness in Hmong families.
  3. Raising more questions about the extent and consequence of hopelessness in Hmong families in particular and immigrant families in general.
- Despite the findings, there were some limitations worth mentioning:
  1. Qualitative study with small and convenient sample size.
  2. Participants were recruited from high risk population.

IMPLICATIONS

- Recommendations include:
  1. Making sure parents and children have access to culturally relevant treatment for or space to talk about their hopelessness.
  2. Motivating community programs to engage parents and children in conversations, especially before adolescence, to minimize the feeling of hopelessness.
  3. Giving incentives for service agencies to work actively to connect Hmong parents to resources so they do not rely on their children as the only source of security.
- We believe these recommendations will:
  1. Reduce healthcare cost to society.
  2. Reduce insecurity and family conflict within Hmong families.
  3. Empower Hmong parents and children to positively deal with new situations.
  4. Reduce feelings of hopelessness within the Hmong community.